

diplomacy, see pp.62–63), and features exchanges between a range of Middle Eastern powers and peoples. These lively letters are the earliest significant evidence of international diplomacy, painting a clear picture of long-distance trading, political agreements, and diplomatic and daily affairs. The letters between Egypt and the Hittites, and specifically between Rameses II and the Hittite king, Hattusili III, with whom the 1258 treaty had been made, discuss issues from international politics to medical problems and wedding plans.

Artistic license

An outstanding feature of Rameses' reign were his buildings. All over Egypt, monuments sprang up or old ones were added to. Giant statues and images of the pharaoh swiftly appeared, and craftsmen wrote inscriptions praising him on every available surface.

He created the new capital city of Per-Rameses in the Nile delta, close to modern-day Cairo. It was beautiful, and convenient for military forays into Asia. He also built the famous temples dedicated to himself and his favorite wife, Nefertari, at Abu Simbel, close to Egypt's modern border with Sudan. The four massive statues of Rameses at Abu Simbel are among the greatest achievements of Egyptian art. Their style was not subtle, but Rameses' creative lead helped the arts to thrive, as they had under his father.

Another major site was Rameses' vast mortuary temple, the Ramesseum. This was built on the west bank of the



Battle of Kadesh

This bas-relief from Abu Simbel portrays Rameses II fighting the Hittites single-handedly. He is seen astride a chariot, wielding a bow and arrow, and wearing the "crown of war."

The Ramesseum

A symbol of the pharaoh's power and wealth, this funerary temple was part of a grand complex including a splendid funerary temple, a palace, a smaller temple dedicated to his parents, courts framed with massive statues of Rameses II himself, and grand avenues of sphinxes.



“What will people say, when it is heard of you [his soldiers] deserting me.”

RAMESES' CLAIM THAT HE FOUGHT THE HITTITES SINGLE-HANDEDLY 1275 BCE

DECISIVE MOMENT

THE FIRST PEACE TREATY

The 1258 peace treaty between Rameses II and Hattusili III was first recorded on a silver tablet (contemporary clay copy shown below). An astonishingly modern document, it is seen as the first real international peace treaty, containing clauses on advanced concepts such as amnesty issues for refugees and extradition for fugitives. It is thought to be such a milestone in international relations that a copy of it hangs in the headquarters of the United Nations.



Nile at Thebes, the southern capital where Rameses created many new architectural projects. A palace, religious and political center, and also a seat of learning, the Ramesseum inspired the English Romantic poet Percy Bysshe Shelley's famous 1817 poem "Ozymandias."

Keeping control

Rameses II kept a tight grip on his lands and on his people. Government records that survive from his rule build a picture of a highly organized leader with a strong interest in law-making and order. With major centers at Per-Rameses and around Thebes, he ensured strong control over both Lower and Upper Egypt. He appointed

a tight web of able officials, including many old friends and many of his own very numerous (over 100) children.

There seems little doubt that Rameses II was a major figure in Middle Eastern history, despite his undoubted skill for

self-promotion. His reign was the last great era of imperial glory for ancient Egypt, and he made his presence felt as far away as modern Turkey. He left a wonderful record of art and history, and a real taste of the grandeur and power of the pharaohs.

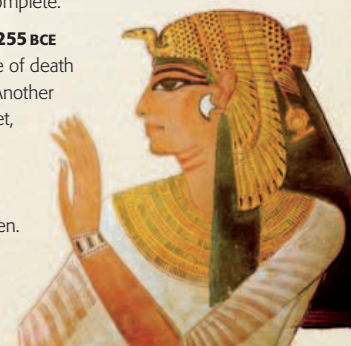
Rameses' mummy

Discovered in the 19th century, the mummy of Rameses II was later unwrapped to reveal his body. He was a tall man for the times, with a long narrow face, prominent nose, large jaw, and red hair. He is thought to be about 90 years old.



TIMELINE

- **c. 1302 BCE** The future Rameses II is born to Seti I, whose family came from nonroyal stock, and his wife Tuya. The crown prince Rameses is made regent while still young, to ensure that he will succeed his father.
- **c. 1292 BCE** The young Rameses bears the rank of army captain at only about 10 years old (this title is probably honorary); accompanies his father on military campaigns to learn his craft.
- **c. 1287 BCE** Rameses is married to Nefertari, who is around 13 years old and younger than her husband. Often said to be his favorite wife, she certainly seems to have been one of his chief wives for around 20 years. He may have had as many as eight wives, but also had a harem.
- **c. 1279 BCE** Rameses is inaugurated as pharaoh, probably in his early to mid-twenties. He begins his reign by traveling south to officiate at his father's funeral in Thebes.
- **c. 1277 BCE** Appears to have defeated some pirates, possibly Shardana people, who have been linked with the mysterious, controversial "Sea People." The defeated pirates appear to have been absorbed into the pharaoh's army.
- **c. 1276 BCE** First campaign in Syria.
- **c. 1275 BCE** Second foray into Syria culminates with the battle of Kadesh against the Hittites, who had long posed a threat to Egyptian power. His opponent is the Hittite king, Muwatalli. The building of Abu Simbel is probably under way.
- **c. 1260s BCE** A large number of Hebrew peoples may be living in Egypt, perhaps forcibly "press-ganged" into the pharaoh's service. There may have been an historically important "Exodus" of these peoples from Egypt into Sinai at some point in the 1260s.
- **c. 1258 BCE** After repeating his father's pattern of years of indecisive power struggles with the Hittites, Rameses and the current Hittite king, Hattusili III, draw up a famous peace agreement.
- **c. 1259–1255 BCE** It is likely the temples at Abu Simbel are complete.
- **c. 1256 or 1255 BCE** Probable date of death of Nefertari. Another wife, Isetnofret, now seems to become Rameses' principal queen.
- **c. 1245 BCE** Rameses marries the eldest daughter of the Hattusili III. She is called Maathorneferure.
- **c. 1230 BCE** Rameses probably marries another Hittite princess.
- **c. 1224 BCE** One of Rameses' many sons, Merneptah, is named as his heir.
- **c. 1213 BCE** Rameses' reign of about 66 years ends with his death, probably from an infection (possibly a dental abscess).



NEFERTARI (MURAL FROM HER TOMB)